

The State of K-12 Staffing

The real numbers behind the shortage — and the path through it.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A market that is short-staffed and shedding jobs at once.

Heading into the 2026 school year, K-12 staffing is defined by a paradox. Schools still cannot find enough qualified educators — 74% of public schools reported difficulty hiring fully certified teachers for 2024-25, and roughly one in eight teaching positions nationwide sits unfilled or filled by an uncertified teacher. Yet the largest one-time federal investment in the system's history — nearly \$190 billion in ESSER pandemic relief, about half of it funding people — expired in September 2024, forcing districts to absorb years of contraction at once.

This report pulls together the most authoritative public data available — from the National Center for Education Statistics, the Learning Policy Institute, the Center on Budget and Policy Priorities, ASCA and NASP — to map where the shortage actually stands, where it is most acute, what it costs, and what districts can do about it. The throughline: the crisis is structural, concentrated in specialized roles, and driven far more by turnover than by retirement. It is exactly the kind of volatility a flexible, exclusive staffing partner is built to absorb.

SECTION 01

The shortage is the norm — and it's a supply problem

Hiring difficulty is no longer the exception. According to the U.S. Department of Education's School Pulse Panel, 74% of public schools struggled to fill one or more teaching vacancies with a fully certified teacher for the 2024-25 year — down only slightly from 79% the prior year. Schools reported an average of six vacancies and filled just 79% of them before classes began.

Crucially, this is a supply problem, not a demand problem: 64% of schools cited an overall lack of qualified candidates and 62% said too few candidates applied. The Learning Policy Institute's national analysis puts hard numbers on it — about 407,000 positions are either unfilled ($\approx 42,000$) or held by teachers who are not fully certified ($\approx 365,000$), roughly one in eight teaching positions in the country.

74%

of public schools had difficulty hiring fully certified teachers (2024-25)

Source: NCES / IES School Pulse Panel

1 in 8

teaching positions nationwide are unfilled or held by an uncertified teacher

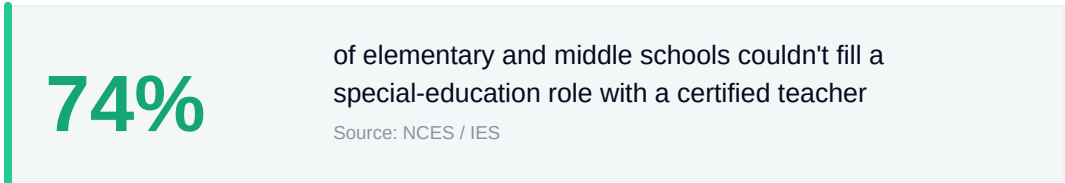
Source: Learning Policy Institute, 2024

SECTION 02

Where it's worst: special education, ESL, math & science

The shortage is not uniform — it is concentrated in the hardest-to-staff specialties. 74% of both elementary and middle schools had difficulty filling a special-education vacancy with a fully certified teacher, and special education topped the list of positions schools needed to fill heading into the next year. High schools reported the most difficulty with ESL/bilingual roles (69%), followed by the perennial gaps in math and science.

Even as overall public-school enrollment shrinks — from 49.6 million in 2022 toward a projected 46.9 million by 2031 — demand for these specialized educators persists. The implication for hiring is clear: generic ‘more teachers’ framing misses the point. The value is in sourcing the credentialed specialists no one else can find.



74%

of elementary and middle schools couldn't fill a special-education role with a certified teacher

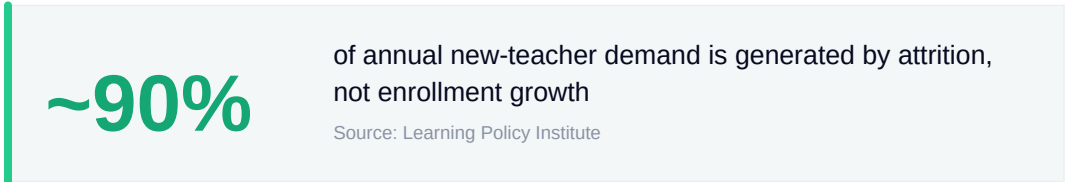
Source: NCES / IES

SECTION 03

Turnover is the engine — and it's expensive

The single most important fact about the teacher shortage is that it is driven by churn, not retirement. Roughly 8% of teachers leave the profession every year — about double the rate of high-performing systems like Finland and Singapore — and attrition accounts for nearly 90% of annual demand for new teachers. Two-thirds of those departures are for reasons other than retirement.

That churn is a hard budget line, not just a staffing inconvenience. The Learning Policy Institute estimates the cost of replacing a single teacher at roughly \$11,860 in small districts, about \$16,450 in mid-sized districts, and nearly \$25,000 in large districts — covering separation, recruiting, hiring and training. Reframed this way, staffing partnership is a cost-containment strategy: the goal is not just to fill the seat, but to stop refilling the same seat.



~90%

of annual new-teacher demand is generated by attrition, not enrollment growth

Source: Learning Policy Institute

up to
~\$25
K

to replace a single teacher in a large district

Source: Learning Policy Institute, 2024

SECTION 04

The ESSER funding cliff meets the shortage

Between 2020 and 2024, schools received nearly \$190 billion in federal ESSER relief — the largest one-time federal investment in K-12 ever. Nearly half of the largest tranche (ESSER III) went to labor: hiring teachers, counselors, administrators, reading and math specialists, and funding salary increases. The obligation deadline passed on September 30, 2024.

Because the money funded people, its expiration translates directly into staffing cuts. Georgetown's Edunomics Lab found that roughly \$24 billion of ESSER III financed recurring annual labor costs, and some experts estimate up to 250,000 education jobs are at risk as the funding unwinds. Counselors, social workers, and instructional coaches — many of them ESSER hires — are the most exposed.

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in federal ESSER relief expired in September 2024 —
about half of it funded staff

Source: Center on Budget and Policy Priorities

SECTION 05

The student mental-health staffing gap

Across all three pupil-services professions, the U.S. operates well below its own recommended standards. The national student-to-counselor ratio is 372:1 against ASCA's recommended 250:1. School psychologists are far worse off — an estimated 1,127:1 against NASP's recommended 500:1 — and no state meets the recommended 250:1 ratio for school social workers.

These gaps were partly papered over by ESSER-funded hires now at risk. The result: the mental-health staffing deficit is poised to widen at precisely the moment student need remains elevated — making school-based clinical and counseling roles among the most urgent to fill.

372:1

students per school counselor nationally, against a recommended 250:1

Source: American School Counselor Association

**1,127
:1**

students per school psychologist, against a recommended 500:1

Source: National Association of School Psychologists

SECTION 06

The substitute and paraprofessional squeeze

Beneath the full-time teacher shortage, the support layer is fraying. About 35% of public schools reported difficulty finding substitute teachers, and special-education support roles — paraprofessionals and aides included — top the list of unfilled positions. When subs and aides are missing, certified teachers and administrators absorb the coverage, sacrificing prep time and accelerating the burnout that feeds the 8% attrition rate.

It is a self-reinforcing loop: missing support staff drives burnout, burnout drives turnover, and turnover deepens the shortage. Staffing flexibility — a reliable bench of vetted, credentialed substitutes and paraprofessionals — is one of the few levers that breaks the cycle.

~35%

of public schools reported difficulty finding substitute teachers

Source: NCES School Pulse Panel

SECTION 07

What works: a focused, flexible staffing model

The data points to a clear set of responses. First, treat the shortage as a specialist-sourcing problem and build a dedicated pipeline for the hardest-to-fill roles. Second, attack time-to-hire and credentialing — automation can roughly halve the time it takes to get a qualified professional in front of students. Third, de-risk hiring with temp-to-perm, so a district can evaluate a professional on the job before committing. And fourth, protect the support layer with a reliable substitute and paraprofessional bench to break the burnout-to-turnover loop.

This is the model FocusedEDU is built on: one client per region for an exclusive, never-shared talent pipeline; automated credentialing that cuts hiring time in half; and temp-to-perm placement at no additional cost.

CASE STUDY

Odyssey Public Charter School: crisis to fully staffed in 60 days

Odyssey Public Charter School in Wilmington, Delaware serves more than 1,000 students. In 2024 it faced a crisis: persistent staffing shortages and a shrinking local talent pool threatened to undercut the school's academic program. FocusedEDU built a dedicated, exclusive pipeline and went to work.

100%	of open teaching and support roles filled	45 18	days average time-to-hire (60% faster)
90%	of hires met or exceeded expectations in their first 90 days	25%	reduction in recruitment spend

All results achieved within 60 days. Individual results vary by district, role mix, and region.

METHODOLOGY & SOURCES

Where the numbers come from

Every statistic in this report is drawn from public, primary or authoritative secondary sources, listed below. Figures reflect the most recent data available as of mid-2026; where a figure is an estimate, it is described as such in the text.

- U.S. Dept. of Education / NCES — School Pulse Panel, 2024-25 hiring challenges. ies.ed.gov
- Learning Policy Institute — State Teacher Shortages: 2024 Update. learningpolicyinstitute.org
- Learning Policy Institute — Teacher Turnover: Why It Matters; and What's the Cost of Teacher Turnover (2024 Update). learningpolicyinstitute.org
- Center on Budget and Policy Priorities — Expiration of Federal K-12 Emergency Funds. cbpp.org
- Edonomics Lab, Georgetown University — ESSER labor-cost analysis.
- American School Counselor Association (ASCA) — School Counselor Roles & Ratios. schoolcounselor.org
- National Association of School Psychologists (NASP) — Shortage of School Psychologists. nasponline.org
- NCES — Condition of Education, Public School Enrollment projections. nces.ed.gov

See where your region stands.

Book a 30-minute discovery call and we'll map your staffing gaps against the 2026 data — and show you how a dedicated, exclusive pipeline closes them. focused-staffing.com